

thought that he presented her with a collection
of his songs (along with one of her own
compositions) on her 18th birthday.

Illness and adversity

Several other factors, in addition to illness, darkened Schubert's life in the 1820s. Paranoid about political subversion in the wake of the French Revolution, the Austrian authorities regarded all unconventional groups of young people with suspicion. In 1820, Schubert and four of his friends were arrested by Viennese police for allegedly insulting imperial officials. Schubert escaped with a reprimand but one of his friends was exiled.

Meanwhile, other members of his group were deserting carefree bohemianism for the security of paid jobs. Schubert continued to make a modest living out of music, but despite a growing reputation as a popular songwriter he found publishers reluctant to print his work and failed to break into the lucrative field of opera. One of his friends, the writer and dramatist Eduard von Bauernfeld, later spoke of "a black-winged demon of sorrow and melancholy" that at times overshadowed the sunnier side of his nature. Somber premonitions of mortality dominate the powerful "Death and the Maiden" String Quartet written in 1824.

Creative impetus

Although even Schubert's admirers tended to see him as primarily a composer of songs, dances, and charming short piano pieces, his deepest ambition was to emulate the monumental achievements of Beethoven, the towering musical genius of his day. But his efforts to